



▲ Sacrificial sheep

Animal sacrifice was a common way of appeasing the gods. This 6th-century BCE votive panel from Pitsa in Greece depicts celebrants offering a sheep to the nymphs to whom the area was sacred.

ENLISTING THE GODS

ancient Greek magic

From Homer's *Iliad* in the Bronze Age to the wider Hellenistic world of the early centuries CE, spell books, amulets, literary accounts, and inscriptions bear witness to the pervasiveness of *mageia* (magic). As with many old belief systems, formal religion and magic were interlinked. Divine influence suffused the whole world, and those empowered to communicate with the gods included priests, philosophers, physicians, and poets.

Formal religion in ancient Greece was a public affair of sacrifice and prayer, festivals and temples. Magic was a more hidden and transgressive form of appeal to the gods, often used for personal gain or to harm others. Although temple priests could perform ritual magic, personal requests were more

often carried out by itinerant magicians and soothsayers, and others on the margins of society, such as prostitutes, who sometimes cast love spells.

Greek philosophers claimed to reject magic, and the authors of the Hippocratic medical text *On Sacred Disease* scorned the notion that spells could cause an eclipse or cure a fever. However, those very same physicians prescribed sleeping in the sacred precinct of the god Asclepius to heal ailments. Greeks at all levels continued to turn

▼ Greek Magical Papyri

This collection of texts was written in Egypt between the 1st century BCE and 4th century CE, and contains spells for love, divination, and healing.

Revelation spell to encourage visions

